

New Hire Onboarding — First Week

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Every new hire is assigned a buddy before their start date. The buddy is never the hiring manager and is usually someone in an adjacent team rather than the immediate one. The reasoning is that the questions which most need answering in a first month are the ones that feel too small to bring to a manager, and people do not ask those of someone who will later write their review. Buddies are expected to hold a thirty minute call on day one, on day three, and at the end of week two, and to be responsive in between.

Day one is deliberately light. Accounts are provisioned in advance across email, Slack, GitHub, 1Password, and Linear, and multi-factor authentication must be enabled on all five before any production access is granted. There is no exception to that sequence, including for senior hires and including where it delays a start. People operations run a 45 minute welcome session at 13:00 EET that covers how the company communicates, where documents live, how decisions get recorded, and what the on-call expectations are for engineering roles.

First week schedule

Day	Focus	Owner	Completion signal
1	Accounts, MFA enrolment, welcome session, buddy call	People Operations	All five accounts active with MFA
2	Local development environment, repository access, architecture walkthrough	Buddy	Test suite runs locally
3	Handbook reading, second buddy call, team standup	Manager	Severity definitions understood
4	First ticket assigned — scoped to be finishable	Manager	Ticket in progress
5	First pull request opened and reviewed	Buddy + reviewer	PR merged to main

Table 1. Expected shape of week one. Support hires substitute ticket shadowing on days 4 and 5.

By day five every engineering hire is expected to have opened at least one pull request. It does not need to be significant, and typo fixes in documentation are explicitly encouraged as a first contribution. The purpose is to walk the entire path from local setup through review to production deploy while someone is still watching closely, so that the first time a new engineer does it alone it is not also the first time they have done it at all. Managers who cannot find a suitable first ticket are expected to manufacture one rather than to skip this.

Equipment

New hires receive a hardware budget as set out below. Laptops are ordered directly by the operations team rather than purchased and reimbursed, because warranty and remote-wipe enrolment both depend on the device being bought through the company account. Peripherals, chairs, and desks are purchased by the employee against a receipt and drawn from the same allowance.

Item	Allowance	Refresh cycle	Ordered by
Laptop	Included in allowance	Every 2 years	Operations team
Peripherals, desk, chair	Included in allowance	Every 2 years	Employee, against receipt
Total per employee	2,500 EUR	Every 2 years	—

Table 2. Hardware allowance for new hires.

Week one reading is short on purpose: this document, the code review guidelines, and the incident severity definitions. Nobody is expected to read the Relay API reference in week one, and a new engineer who reports having read it is gently redirected. Support hires additionally read the escalation policy and shadow two live tickets before taking one of their own. Everything else in the handbook is reference material to be read when the situation arises.

The 30-60-90 review happens with the hiring manager at the end of the first, second, and third month. There is no formal performance rating attached to any of them and nothing from them is retained after the probation period closes. They exist to catch a bad fit early in either direction, and roughly one hire in twelve uses the sixty day conversation to raise something structural that would otherwise have surfaced six months later as attrition.